

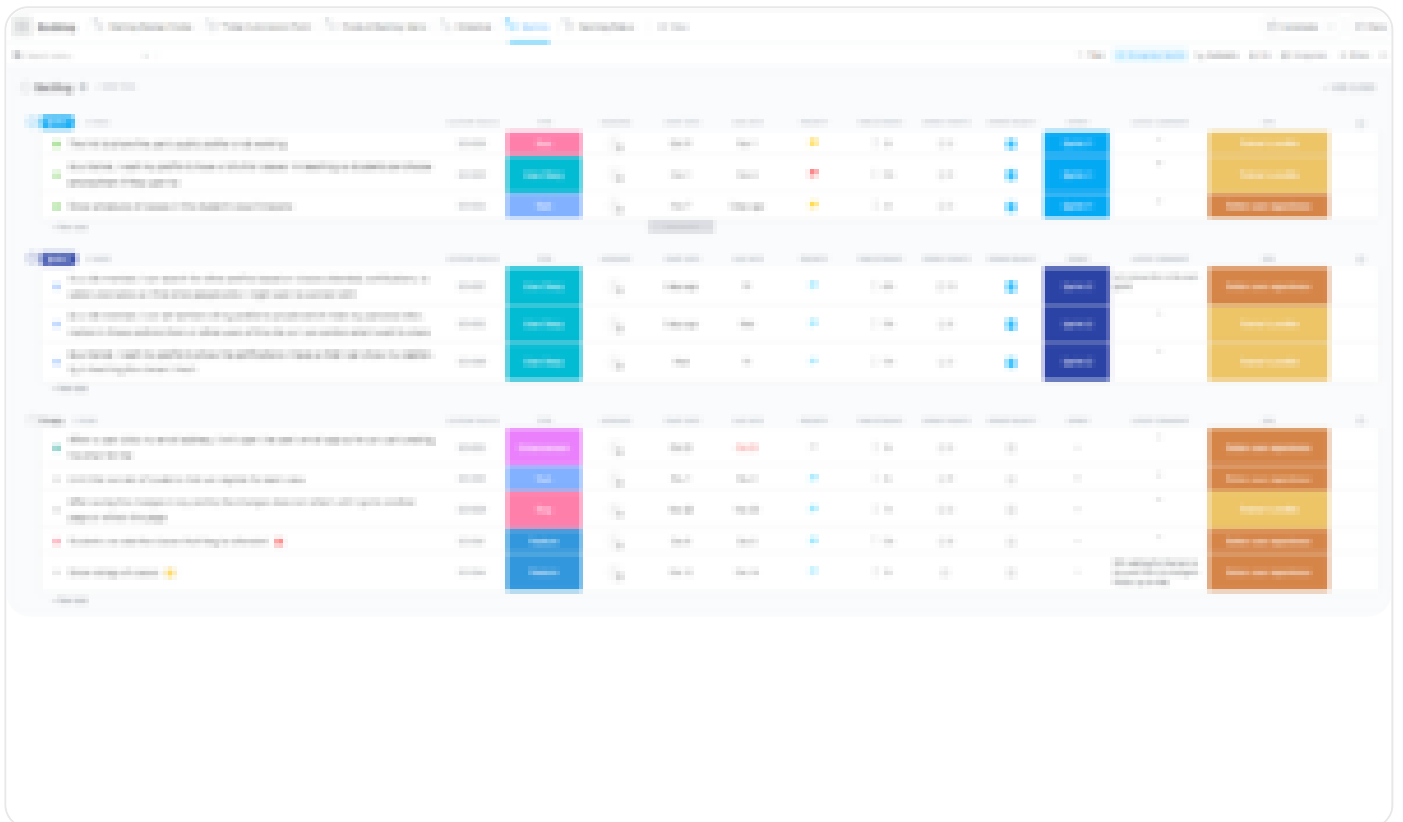
PRODUCT

How to Manage a Product Backlog? With Examples & Templates

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Feb 12, 2024

[Get This Free Product Backlog Template](#)

In the real world, a backlog means the accumulation of uncompleted tasks. In college, backlog is an exam you haven't passed yet. "I have a huge backlog" isn't a good thing. However, that is not the case in agile product development.

In agile scrum, the product backlog is a wishlist or a future plan, while the sprint backlog is the planned task list for a sprint. While the word backlog still means tasks not yet completed, its purpose in agile is distinct.

But first, let's understand backlogs.

What is a Product Backlog?

A [product backlog](#) is a list of tasks, features, user stories, and bug fixes the development team will work on while executing the product roadmap. It is characterized by the following.

- Acts as the single source of requirements for the development team
- Breaks down the high-level organizational vision into tasks
- Prioritizes the items and features on the product roadmap
- Stays dynamic, evolving with the needs of the market, consumer, and organization

What does the product backlog contain?

Essentially, a product backlog contains everything that agile teams need to work on. This can be:

- New features
- Existing feature enhancements
- Bug fixes
- Customer requests
- Action items from the retrospective
- Technical debt
- Infrastructure updates



Featured Template

Prioritize features, fixes, and ideas in one place with [ClickUp's Backlog Template](#). Easily groom your product backlog and keep your team aligned on

what's coming next. Try it for free today!

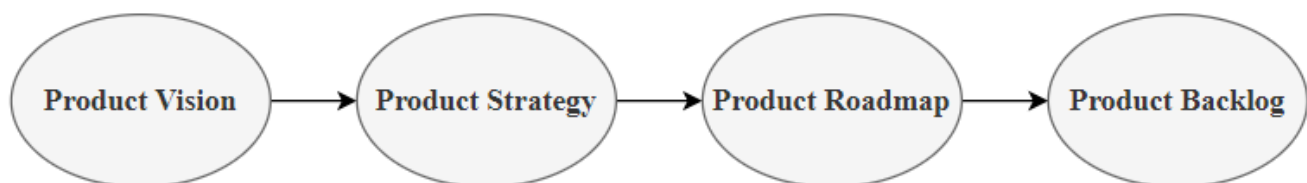
The screenshot displays the ClickUp Backlog Template interface. It features a navigation bar at the top with options like 'Backlog', 'Getting Started Guide', 'Ticket Submission Form', 'Product Backlog Items', 'Schedule', 'Sprints', 'Backlog Status', and 'View'. Below the navigation bar, there's a search bar and a filter section. The main content area is divided into three sections: 'Sprint 1', 'Sprint 2', and 'Empty'. Each section contains a table of tasks with columns for Custom Task ID, Type, Assignee, Start Date, Due Date, Priority, Time Estimate, Sprint Points, Sprint Ready, Sprint, Latest Comment, and Epic. The tasks are color-coded by type: Bug (pink), User Story (blue), Task (purple), Enhancement (green), and Feature (orange). The 'Sprint 1' section shows tasks for 'Trainer's profile' and 'Better user experience'. The 'Sprint 2' section shows tasks for 'Better user experience' and 'Trainer's profile'. The 'Empty' section shows tasks for 'Better user experience' and 'Trainer's profile'.

Manage your product backlog with ClickUp's Backlog Template

Who owns the product backlog?

The product owner owns the product backlog, publishing it on the [product management tool](#). However, the entire [cross-functional team](#) and the scrum master take responsibility for creating, updating, and maintaining it.

How is the product backlog different from the product roadmap?



Product development journey

The product backlog is a detailed breakdown of the product roadmap. While the roadmap communicates high-level objectives and direction, the backlog includes task-level details on its execution.

The roadmap supports the business teams and managers, while the product backlog is for the developers. The roadmap focuses on metrics and goals, while the product backlog outlines tasks and [action items](#).

What does the product backlog look like?

Here is a product backlog example. We've considered the features of an online multiplayer game. Each feature is assigned a story point, and the backlog items are ordered based on their priority, with the highest priority (priority=1) item at the top.

User Story	Story Point(s)	Priority
As a gamer, I want to invite my friends so we can play together	1	1
As a gamer, I want a practice mode so I can learn how to play	2	2
As a gamer, I want to have in-app chat so that I can talk to other players in real time	3	2
As a gamer, I want to compare heroes so I can choose the right one for me	4	3
As a gamer, I want resources that boost my hero's health and mana regen	3	3
As a gamer, I want in-game money so I can purchase hero customizations	3	4

Example of a product backlog

For a sample of what it might look like for you, see the [ClickUp project backlog template](#). You can customize it for your product instantly, too!

[Get Free Template](#)

Benefits of Having a Product Backlog

As one of the foundational [scrum artifacts](#), the agile backlog offers structure and actionability to product development. Here's how.

Team agility

The product owner shares the product backlog with the entire team, opening it up for discussion before every sprint. The team prioritizes together, having conversations around what's important. These discussions create better collaboration among team members, supporting innovation.

Iteration planning

An agile [scrum team](#) adds all tasks to the backlog. For each iteration in agile projects, the team evaluates the backlog, identifies items for development, discusses trade-offs, and creates the [sprint backlog](#).

Anchor for work

When the developers take items from the backlog to develop, they are anchored to it. It prevents them from deviating from the plan or feeling lost in the middle of the sprint.

Accommodating feedback

An agile product backlog documents feedback from customers/users as well as action items from team retrospectives. This helps in continuous improvement, which is foundational to agile product development.

With all these benefits and more, product backlogs play a critical role in the agile framework.

The Role of Product Backlog Management in Agile

The product backlog serves a specific purpose within the agile software development framework. The product development journey looks as follows.

Product vision > Product strategy > Product roadmap > Product backlog > Sprint backlog > Product release

In this journey, the product backlog converts the vision and roadmap into actionable tasks. It helps leadership see how their vision will be executed. It shows the development team how their [daily work](#) contributes to the business and serves as the superset of features for sprint backlogs.

A healthy product backlog is the primary determinant of an effective sprint backlog.

Product backlog vs. sprint backlog

	Product backlog	Sprint backlog
Purpose	Lists tasks that the team can perform in upcoming sprints	Lists tasks that the team has committed to completing in the next sprint
Size	Superset of tasks	Subset of the product backlog
Items	Product features and customer requests	User stories with software requirement
Duration	Ongoing	Each sprint
Ownership	Product owner	Development team
Reporting	Dashboard with number of features, points, and time estimated	Sprint burndown chart

Differences between product backlog and sprint backlog

How to Prioritize Product Backlog Items?

One of the critical jobs of the product owner in product backlog management is prioritization. The product owner decides what the team must focus on to maximize value.

Parameters for backlog prioritization

Therefore, the critical parameter for prioritizing product backlog items is value. Business value can be any of the following.

- Customer needs or satisfaction
- Revenue or profitability
- Risk management or compliance
- Product differentiation for competitive advantage

The value used to prioritize backlog can also be internal and defined at an engineering level.

- Time to develop a feature
- Resources/costs needed to develop

If you need help, the [Aha! product management](#) software can help identify these parameters by connecting strategic goals to everyday tasks.

Backlog prioritization techniques

You can follow any of the following techniques based on the value you choose to prioritize.

Kano model: Plotted on a graph, the Kano model compares customer delight to implementation investment. It helps teams prioritize features likely to satisfy customers and realize investment.

MoSCoW model: This is an abbreviation for must-have, should-have, could-have, and won't-have, helping teams prioritize the essential features over clutter.

Cumulative voting: Every stakeholder is given 100 points—or figurative dollars—that team members can spend on the features of their choice. The features most paid for are the ones that get prioritized.

Stack ranking: Instead of listing and prioritizing all items, this method stacks one user story against another and makes individual decisions about priority.

Smallest effort first: If the team needs quick wins, the product owner prioritizes the easiest or simplest tasks.

Cost of delay: With this method, you prioritize tasks with the most opportunity cost. If moving a feature development by two weeks will cost something, such as a lost business opportunity or vulnerability in the product, you prioritize that from the backlog.

Managing a product backlog can be challenging, with so many factors influencing prioritization and so many techniques. Here are some of the common challenges product teams face.

Challenges in Managing a Product Backlog

Ambiguous user needs: One of the biggest challenges of managing a product backlog is not knowing clearly what the customer wants. Vague user stories can derail development.

Overloaded backlog: A product backlog isn't a dump of every idea everyone ever had. It is a refined list of features/tasks that make business sense. The backlog can

become unwieldy if the product owner cannot eliminate unimportant/irrelevant user stories.

Decision fatigue: An unwieldy backlog means too many decisions for the product manager. This can be overwhelming and lead to decision fatigue.

Aged backlog: A product backlog needs to be updated to be helpful. If your team either neglects the backlog or doesn't update it, it can become irrelevant and, therefore, not adopted.

Incomplete definition: Every item on the backlog needs to be clearly defined. Managing the backlog becomes challenging when business users and product owners don't do this.

Changing priorities: While agile teams expect and can adapt to evolving needs, changing priorities in the middle of a sprint can be disruptive.

All of these challenges can be overcome with a clear, strategic, and collaborative product backlog management process.

How to Create and Manage a Product Backlog

Creating and managing the product backlog is one of the product owner's most critical responsibilities. Getting it right will set the foundation for successful [agile product development](#).

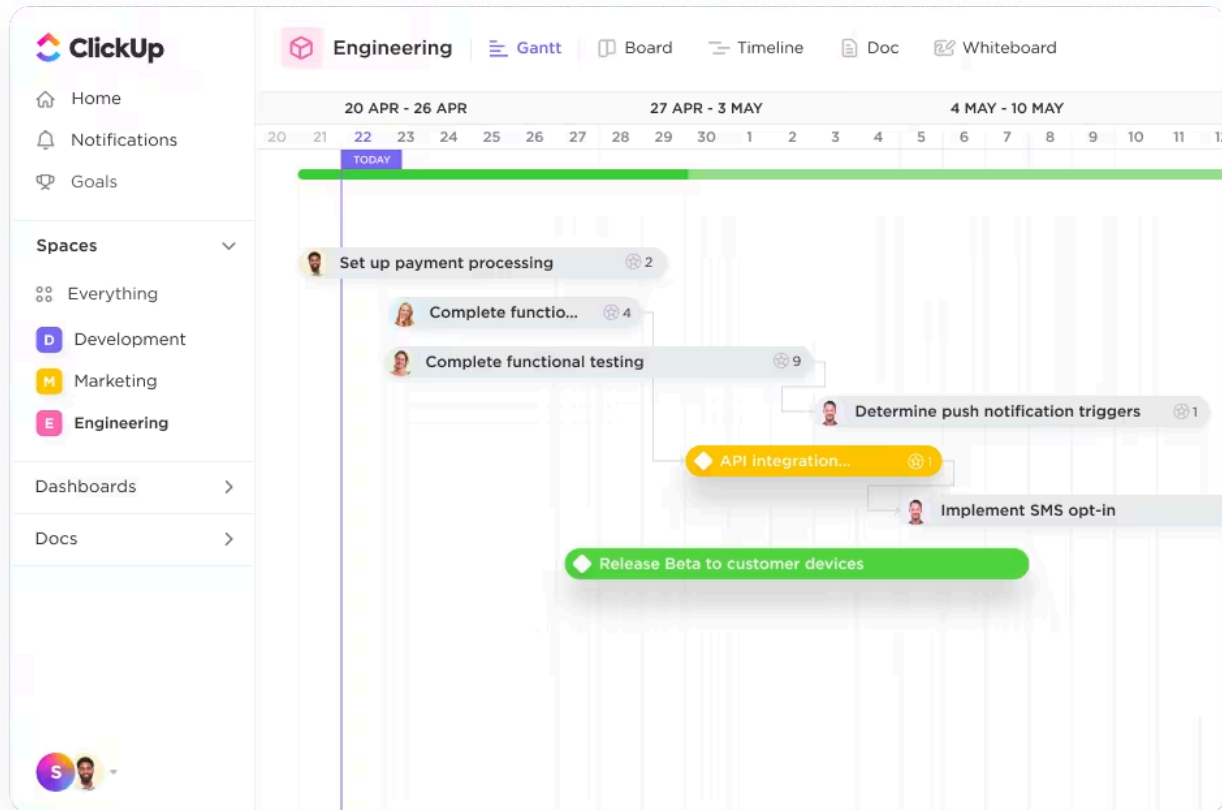
You need a comprehensive, flexible, and efficient way to create backlog items and manage your product backlog. There are several [product backlog management tools](#) available in the market today.

Here's how you can use a tool like [ClickUp for product management](#) to get it right.

1. Use your product roadmap

The product roadmap is the starting point for creating your backlog. It distills the organizational and product vision into direction and gives the business perspective fundamental to engineering efforts.

So, understand the product roadmap clearly and use it to guide your development journey. Visual roadmaps on ClickUp can help engineering, product, and business teams rally toward the same goals.



Product roadmap in ClickUp

2. Collect potential features for the backlog

The roadmap is the first of many sources that can suggest features for your product backlog. Here are some insightful places to look.

User research: Conduct user research to help you identify what users want. A simple survey using [ClickUp Forms](#) can be a great starting point.

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